“Śrī Caitanya-caritāmṛta”

Ādi-līlā

Chapter 12

The Description of the Branches of the Advaita Trunk

(English translation from the Bengali, following the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition and the Anubhāṣya, 2026)

1 Like bees, all the followers of Śrī Advaita hover about His lotus feet, yet some of them hold the essence and others are empty. Rejecting the empty, I bow to those who hold the essence, whose very life is Śrī Caitanya.[1]

2 Glory, glory to Mahāprabhu Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya! Glory, glory to Nityānanda, and glory to the blessed Advaita!

3 The glorious Advaitacandra is the second trunk of the immortal tree of Śrī Caitanya, and His followers are the branches of that trunk. To them we bow down.

4 The second trunk of the tree is Ācārya Gosāñi. So many branches grew from Him that there is no writing them all down.

5 Caitanya the gardener waters this trunk with His mercy, and, nourished by that water, it grows day by day.[2]

6 So many fruits of love for Kṛṣṇa ripened on that trunk that they filled the whole world.

7 Through the trunk that water rises into the branches, and they spread far and wide, laden with flowers and fruit.

8 At first the Ācārya's followers were all of one mind; but later, as fate would have it, two views arose among them.

9 Some kept to the Ācārya's order; others, in the grip of fate, grew self-willed and invented doctrines of their own.[3]

10 The Ācārya's teaching is the essence; whoever goes against His order is empty, mere chaff.[4]

11 There is no need here to name the empty ones; I list them together only to make the difference plain.

12 It is like a heap of paddy: one first measures it along with its chaff, and afterwards winnows the chaff away to clean the grain.[5]

13 Acyutānanda, the Ācārya's son, is a great branch. From his very birth he served the feet of Śrī Caitanya.[6]

14 When he heard his father say that Keśava Bhāratī was the guru of Caitanya Gosāñi, he was deeply pained.

15 "How can You teach such a thing about the guru of the world?" he said. "This teaching of Yours will bring ruin on the whole land.

16 Caitanya Gosāñi is the guru of the fourteen worlds; no scripture anywhere says that anyone else is His guru."

17 Hearing a boy of five speak the very essence of the scriptures' conclusions, the Ācārya was boundlessly pleased.[7]

18 Another of the Ācārya's sons was named Kṛṣṇa Miśra, and Caitanya Gosāñi dwelt in his heart.[8]

19 Śrī Gopāla was yet another son of the Ācārya. Listen to his story, for it is most wonderful.

20 When Mahāprabhu was cleansing the Guṇḍicā temple, Gopāla danced before Him in the kīrtana, filled with the great joy of love.[9]

21 Many ecstasies arose in his body, and his dancing was wondrous; the two Gosāñis, delighted at heart, called out, "Hari!"[10]

22 In the midst of his dancing Gopāla fainted and fell to the ground, with no sign of awareness left in his body.

23 The Ācārya was grieved. Taking His son on His lap, He recited the mantra of Nṛsiṁha to protect him.

24 He recited mantra after mantra, but the boy did not come to, and the Vaiṣṇavas wept to see the Ācārya's grief.

25 Then Mahāprabhu placed His hand on the boy's chest and said, "Get up, Gopāla! Say 'Hari! Hari!'"

26 Feeling the Lord's touch and hearing His voice, Gopāla rose, and everyone, overjoyed, raised the cry of "Hari!"

27 The Ācārya had other sons as well: Śrī Balarāma, Svarūpa and one named Jagadīśa.[11]

28 The Ācārya had a servant named Kamalākānta Viśvāsa, who knew all His affairs.[12]

29 In Nīlācala he wrote a letter and sent it to King Pratāparudra.

30 The Ācārya knew nothing about the letter, and somehow it found its way to the Lord.

31 In that letter he had proclaimed the Ācārya to be God Himself.

32 “But by fate,” it went on, “He has fallen into some debt, and to pay it off I ask for three hundred coins.”

33 The Lord read the letter and was pained at heart; yet, smiling outwardly, the moon-faced One said:

34 “He has proclaimed the Ācārya to be God, and in that there is no fault: the Ācārya truly is God.

35 But he has made God out to be poor and gone begging for Him. So I shall punish him and teach him a lesson.”[13]

36 He ordered Govinda, “From today on, do not let that madcap Viśvāsa come here.”[14]

37 Viśvāsa was deeply distressed to hear of his punishment, but when the Ācārya heard of it, He was delighted.

38 He said to Viśvāsa, “You are most fortunate: the Lord, Bhagavān Himself, has punished you.

39 In the past Mahāprabhu used to honour Me. This pained Me, and I thought of a way to change it.

40 I expounded the *Yoga-vāsiṣṭha*, extolling liberation as the highest goal, and the Lord grew angry and treated Me with dishonour.[15]

41 Being punished brought Me the greatest joy; fortunate Śrī Mukunda received the same punishment.

42 So did the fortunate Śrī Śacī. Where else could anyone find such mercy in the guise of punishment?”[16]

43 With these words the Ācārya comforted him, and then, joyful, He went to Mahāprabhu.

44 He said to the Lord, “I do not understand this pastime of Yours. You have made Kamalā a greater vessel of Your mercy than Me.

45 Such mercy You have never shown even Me. What offence have I committed at Your feet?”

46 Hearing this, Mahāprabhu began to laugh; He sent for Kamalākānta and was gracious to him.

47 The Ācārya said, “Why have You let him see You again? He makes a mockery of Me in two ways.”[17]

48 The Lord was pleased at heart to hear this. Only the two of Them knew what lay within each other’s words.

49 The Lord said, “Madcap, why do you behave like this? What you do harms the Ācārya’s honour and His dharma.

50 A Vaiṣṇava ācārya must never accept a king’s wealth as a gift. If he eats the food of worldly men, his mind is defiled.[18]

51 When the mind is defiled, one cannot remember Kṛṣṇa, and without remembrance of Kṛṣṇa life bears no fruit.

52 It brings shame before the world and ruins one's dharma and good name. Know this, and never do such a thing."[19]

53 This teaching was meant for everyone, and everyone took it to heart, while Ācārya Gosāñi rejoiced within.

54 Only the Lord understood the Ācārya's intention, and the Ācārya understood the Lord's deep words.

55 There is much to consider in this episode, but I cannot write of it for fear of making the book too long.

56 Śrī Yadunandana Ācārya is a branch of Advaita; his own branches and offshoots are past all writing.

57 He received the mercy of Vāsudeva Datta and with all his heart took shelter of Śrī Caitanya's feet.[20]

58 Other branches are Bhāgavata Ācārya, Viṣṇudāsa Ācārya, Cakrapāṇi Ācārya and Ananta Ācārya.[21]

59 Then come Nandinī, Kāmadeva, Caitanya dāsa, Durlabha Viśvāsa and Vanamāli dāsa.

60 Jagannātha Kara, Bhavanātha Kara, Hṛdayānanda Sena and Bholānātha dāsa.

61 Yādava dāsa, Vijaya dāsa, Janārdana, Ananta dāsa, Kānu Paṇḍita and Nārāyaṇa dāsa.

62 Śrīvatsa Paṇḍita, Haridāsa Brahmacārī, Puruṣottama Brahmacārī and Kṛṣṇadāsa.

63 Puruṣottama Paṇḍita, Raghunātha, Vanamālī Kavicandra and Vaidyanātha.

64 Lokanātha Paṇḍita, Murāri Paṇḍita, Śrī Haricaraṇa and Mādhava Paṇḍita.

65 Vijaya Paṇḍita and Śrī Rāma Paṇḍita. The branches of Advaita are countless, so how many names can I give?[22]

66 The water of mercy the gardener gives sustains the Advaita trunk, and by it the branches live and bear flowers and fruit.[23]

67 But when Caitanya the gardener had concluded His manifest pastimes, some of these branches, to their misfortune, turned their backs on Him.[24]

68 He had brought them forth and kept them alive, yet they would not accept Him. They proved ungrateful, and the trunk grew angry with them.

69 In its anger the trunk let no water pass to them, and for want of water the branches withered, dried up and died.

70 A body without consciousness (*caitanya*) is like dry wood. So too, one without Caitanya is dead while still alive, and when he dies, Yama punishes him.[25]

71 This punishment is not for these alone: whoever turns away from Caitanya is a *pāṣaṇḍa*, a godless man.

72 Scholar or ascetic, householder or sannyāsī — whoever turns away from Caitanya meets this fate.

73 Those followers of the Ācārya who accepted the view of Śrī Acyutānanda are *mahā-bhāgavatas*, great devotees.

74 It is they who received the Ācārya's mercy, and without effort they attained the feet of Caitanya.[26]

75 To those followers of the Ācārya who are like Acyutānanda, whose very life is Caitanya, I offer obeisances millions of times.

76 Thus I have told of the followers of Ācārya Gosāñi, and have briefly counted the branches of the three trunks.[27]

77 The offshoots of these branches are past counting; I have told only a little, to give a glimpse of them.

78 The offshoots of Śrī Gadādhara Paṇḍita are most excellent, and I shall now name some of them.[28]

79 The finest of them is Dhruvānanda; after him come Śrīdhara Brahmacārī, Bhāgavatācārya and Haridāsa Brahmacārī.[29]

80 Ananta Ācārya, Kavidatta, Nayana Miśra, Gaṅgāmantrī, Māmu Ṭhākura and Kaṇṭhābharaṇa.[30]

81 Bhūgarbha Gosāñi and Bhāgavata dāsa both came to Vṛndāvana and made their home there.[31]

82 Vāṇīnātha Brahmacārī was a great soul, and Vallabha-caitanya dāsa was full of love for Kṛṣṇa.

83 Śrīnātha Cakravartī, Uddhava dāsa, Jitāmitra and Jagannātha dāsa of Kāṣṭhakāṭā.[32]

84 Śrī Hari Ācārya, Puriyā Gopāla dāsa, Kṛṣṇadāsa Brahmacārī and Puṣpagopāla.[33]

85 Śrīharṣa, Raghu Miśra, Lakṣmīnātha Paṇḍita, Caitanya dāsa of Baṅgavāṭī and Śrī Raghunātha.

86 Amogha Paṇḍita, Hastigopāla, Caitanya-vallabha, Yadu Gāṅguli and Maṅgala Vaiṣṇava.

87 Among the branches Śivānanda Cakravartī stood out in his ardour; his heart found its rest at the feet of Madana-gopāla.[34]

88 Thus I have briefly told of the Paṇḍita's followers; in the same way one could count many other branches and offshoots.[35]

89 All the Paṇḍita's followers are blessed devotees, and Śrī Kṛṣṇa Caitanya is the beloved of their lives.

90 I have now counted the branches of these three trunks. Whoever remembers them is freed from the bondage of worldly existence.[36]

91 By remembering them one attains the feet of Śrī Caitanya; by remembering them every desire is fulfilled.

92 Therefore I bow down at the feet of them all, and now I shall tell, in due order, the pastimes of Caitanya the gardener.

93 The nectar ocean of Gaura's pastimes is shoreless and fathomless. Who could even dream of plunging into it?[37]

94 Yet the fragrance of its sweetness entices my heart, and so, standing on the shore, I taste a single drop.

95 Praying at the feet of Śrī Rūpa and Śrī Raghunātha, I, Kṛṣṇadāsa, narrate the *Caitanya-caritāmṛta*.

Notes

1. Heading in the edition: “The servants of Advaita are of two kinds: those who take the essence (*sāra-grāhī*) and the empty.” *Anubhāṣya*: *sāra*, the essence, are the people of Gaurahari who follow Advaita; *asāra*, the empty, are those who merely fancy themselves His followers but have turned away from Gaurahari — Māyāvādīs devoid of pure devotion; those who hold the essence are the *bhāgavatas*, whose life is Gaura. According to the edition’s *Kathāsāra*, the author calls *sāra-grāhī* the Vaiṣṇavas who follow the view of Śrī Acyutānanda (12.73), and all the rest *asāra*. ↩
2. Heading in the edition: “By Gaura’s mercy only those servants of Advaita who take the essence flourish.” ↩
3. Heading in the edition: “Those who take the essence serve Gaura in loyalty to Advaita; the empty, going their own way, oppose Gaura.” ↩
4. Heading in the edition: “Loyalty to the Ācārya is the essence; anything else is empty.” *Sāra* is “essence, kernel”; *asāra*, “empty, without a kernel”. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: those who walk the path the Ācārya taught are pure Vaiṣṇavas; those who, subject to fate, left it and invented a teaching of their own are *asāra*. ↩
5. Heading in the edition to 11–12: “Why the non-devotees who fancy themselves servants of Advaita are mentioned, and an example.” *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: we have no concern with the names of the *asāra*; yet, to keep the Vaiṣṇavas who take the essence apart from the empty, I name them together, as chaff is winnowed from the grain. Chaff (*pātanā*) is the empty paddy that holds no rice. ↩
6. In the edition the branches of Śrī Advaita are listed under numbered headings: (1) Acyutānanda, (2) Kṛṣṇa Miśra, (3) Gopāla, (4) Kamalākānta Viśvāsa, (5) Yadunandana Ācārya, (6)–(38) in 12.58–65; the offshoots of Gadādhara Paṇḍita are numbered (1)–(33), 12.79–87. *Anubhāṣya*: Acyutānanda was Advaita’s eldest son (*Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Antya 9). Devoted to Mahāprabhu from

childhood, he never married; later, in Purī, he took shelter of Śrī Gadādhara Paṇḍita, and the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* calls him Gadādhara's disciple (some see in him Kārttikeya, others the gopī Acyutā). ↩

7. *Anubhāṣya*: in the year Mahāprabhu set His heart on going from Nīlācala to Vṛndāvana by way of Rāmakeli (1433–34 of the Śaka era), Acyutānanda was only five years old (*Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Antya 4). ↩
8. *Anubhāṣya* (after the *Advaita-carita*): of Advaita's six sons, three — Acyuta, Kṛṣṇa Miśra and Gopāla — served Śrī Gaurāṅga; they are called the three jewels born from the ocean of Sītā's womb. ↩
9. The edition's *Kathāsāra*: this was in Gopāla's youth, at the cleansing of the Guṇḍicā temple. *Anubhāṣya*: see Madhya 12.143–149. ↩
10. The two Gosāñis are Mahāprabhu and Advaita. ↩
11. *Anubhāṣya*: Balarāma, Svarūpa and Jagadīśa turned away from Gaura; they were *smārtas* or Māyāvādīs, and therefore not Vaiṣṇavas (compare 12.1 and 12.10: "the empty"). ↩
12. The *Anubhāṣya* distinguishes Kamalākānta Viśvāsa, Advaita's servant, from the brāhmaṇa Kamalākānta of Navadvīpa, whom Paramānanda Purī brought with him to Nīlācala (Madhya 10.94). ↩
13. Heading in the edition: "To take Nārāyaṇa, full in all six opulences, for a poor man, as though He were a jīva, is Māyāvāda, the creed of the *bāuls*." *Anubhāṣya*: *īśvarera dainya kari'* — "making the Lord out to be poor". ↩
14. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: Kamalākānta Viśvāsa was called "the madcap Viśvāsa" because his conclusions were like the ravings of a madman (*bāul*). ↩
15. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya*: while explaining the *Yoga-vāsiṣṭha*, Advaita on some pretext declared liberation higher than devotion. *Anubhāṣya*: the *Yoga-vāsiṣṭha Rāmāyaṇa* teaches Māyāvāda — liberation as *nirvāṇa*, merging into Brahman — and is opposed to devotion to Viṣṇu; pure devotees therefore do not read it. ↩
16. *Anubhāṣya*: for Advaita's punishment see *Caitanya-bhāgavata*, Madhya 19; for Mukunda's, Madhya 10; for Mother Śacī's, Madhya 22. ↩
17. *Anubhāṣya*: "He calls Me the transcendent Nārāyaṇa, yet in practice he takes Me for a poor worldly man begging for money." ↩
18. Heading in the edition to 50–52: "The Lord sets out the duty of a Vaiṣṇava ācārya." ↩
19. *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* to 49–53: though the Ācārya is Īśvara, His human pastime as the teacher of the world is well known, and for an ācārya to beg money from a king to pay a debt is shameless. Greed must be shunned in every way; a king is by nature a worldly man, and eating his food defiles the heart;

with a defiled heart one does not remember Kṛṣṇa, and life passes without fruit. This is forbidden to all, and to ācāryas above all: one who gives instruction in the holy name for money is no teacher of the name but an offender against it. ↩

20. *Anubhāṣya*: Yadunandana Ācārya was the initiating guru of Śrī Raghunātha dāsa Gosvāmī (Antya 6.160–169). Vāsudeva Datta is Madhuvrata, a singer of Vraja (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā*, 140; see Ādi 10.41). ↩
21. *Anubhāṣya*: Bhāgavata Ācārya was first among Advaita's followers and later among Gadādhara's; he wrote the *Prema-taraṅgiṇī* (*Śākhā-nirṇayāmṛta* 6). Viṣṇudāsa Ācārya went with Acyutānanda to the festival at Kheturi. Ananta Ācārya is Sudevī, one of the eight sakhīs of Vraja; later he too joined the branch of Gadādhara (see 12.80). ↩
22. *Anubhāṣya*: Śrī Rāma Paṇḍita is the younger brother of Śrīvāsa Paṇḍita (see Ādi 10.8); in the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (91) he is the sage Parvata, Nārada's friend. ↩
23. Heading in the edition: "By the power of Gaura's mercy the servants of Advaita who take the essence flourish." ↩
24. Heading in the edition to 67–69: "Only the unfortunate empty ones, who fancy themselves servants of Advaita, oppose Gaura, and, bereft of His mercy, perish." *Amṛta-pravāha-bhāṣya* to 67–73: Advaita is a trunk of the wish-fulfilling tree of bhakti; Śrī Caitanya, as the gardener, waters and nourishes that trunk and its branches. But some branches, by misfortune, behind the gardener's back refused to accept Him and declared the trunk alone to be the cause of the tree. Ungratefully they rejected Mahāprabhu, who created and sustains the Advaita trunk; no more water reached those sinful branches, and, for want of water, they withered, dried up and died. ↩
25. A play on words: *caitanya-rahita* means both "without consciousness" and "without Caitanya". Heading in the edition: "The devotee of Gaura-Kṛṣṇa is a guru to Yama; one who turns from Gaura-Kṛṣṇa is subject to Yama's punishment." The *Anubhāṣya* quotes Yama's words to his messengers (*Śrīmad-Bhāgavatam* 6.3.29): "Bring me those wicked ones whose tongue does not speak the names and qualities of the Lord, whose heart does not remember His lotus feet, whose head has not bowed even once to Kṛṣṇa — those who have not done their duty to Viṣṇu." ↩
26. Heading in the edition to 73–74: "Only Acyuta's followers take the essence: they are devotees of Gaura who have received Advaita's mercy." Some editions add a verse here: "অচ্যুতের যেই মত, সেই মত সার / আর যত মত সব হইল ছারখার" ("The view of Acyuta is the essence; all other views have crumbled to dust"). It is not in the Gauḍīya Maṭha edition, and the numbering follows the edition. ↩

27. The three trunks are the main trunk, Śrī Caitanya Himself (Ādi 9.12; Ādi 10), and the trunks of Śrī Nityānanda (Ādi 11) and Śrī Advaita; the followers of Gadādhara Paṇḍita the author goes on to call offshoots (12.78). ↩
28. Gadādhara Paṇḍita himself is a great branch of the main trunk (Ādi 10.15). Heading in the edition: "Śrī Gadādhara's disciples, or offshoots." Other editions read here *paṇḍita śākhāte mahottama*, "Paṇḍita is the most excellent among the branches". ↩
29. *Anubhāṣya*: Dhruvānanda Brahmacārī is, according to the *Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* (152), Lalitā, one of her manifestations; the *Śākhā-nirṇayāmṛta* says that Śrī Gadādhara in his mercy bestowed his own nature on him. Śrīdhara Brahmacārī is Candralatikā (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 194, 199). Haridāsa Brahmacārī is counted among the followers both of Advaita (12.62) and of Gadādhara. The edition's heading names Bhāgavatācārya "Raghunātha Bhāgavatācārya". ↩
30. *Anubhāṣya*: Mahāprabhu called Māmu Ṭhākura *māmā*, "uncle" (mother's brother), and so he came to be known; his real name was Jagannātha Cakravartī, and he was a nephew of Nīlāmbara Cakravartī. After Gadādhara's departure he took charge of the service of Śrī Ṭoṭā-gopīnātha in Purī. Kaṇṭhābharaṇa is Ananta Caṭṭarāja (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 196, 206). ↩
31. *Anubhāṣya*: Bhūgarbha Gosvāmī is Prema-mañjarī (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 187), the bosom friend of Śrī Lokanātha Gosvāmī; he served Śrī Govindadeva in Vṛndāvana. Bhāgavata dāsa was his companion (*Śākhā-nirṇayāmṛta* 31). ↩
32. *Anubhāṣya*: Kāṣṭhakāṭā (Kāṭhādiyā) was Jagannātha dāsa's village in Vikramapura, in the district of Dhaka; the *Śākhā-nirṇayāmṛta* (48) says that he brought the blessing of the holy name to Tripura. ↩
33. *Anubhāṣya*, after the *Śākhā-nirṇayāmṛta* (38): Gopāla dāsa of Sādipura preached the holy name in Vikramapura. Kṛṣṇadāsa Brahmacārī is Indulekhā, one of the eight sakhīs (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 164); he lived in Vṛndāvana. ↩
34. *Anubhāṣya*: Śivānanda Cakravartī is a manifestation of Lavaṅga-mañjarī (*Gaura-gaṇoddeśa-dīpikā* 183); he lived in Vṛndāvana (see Ādi 8.70). ↩
35. *Anubhāṣya*: in the *Śākhā-nirṇaya* Yadunandana dāsa names twenty-three more branches of Gadādhara, among them Vallabha Bhaṭṭa (after whom the Vallabha sampradāya, the path of *puṣṭi*, is known), Madhu Paṇḍita (who established the service of Śrī Gopīnātha in Vṛndāvana) and Lokanātha Bhaṭṭa (the guru of Ṭhākura Narottama). ↩
36. Heading in the edition to 90–91: "The glory of remembering the followers of Nitāi, Advaita and Gadādhara." ↩

37. Heading in the edition to 93–94: “The author’s humility.” ↩